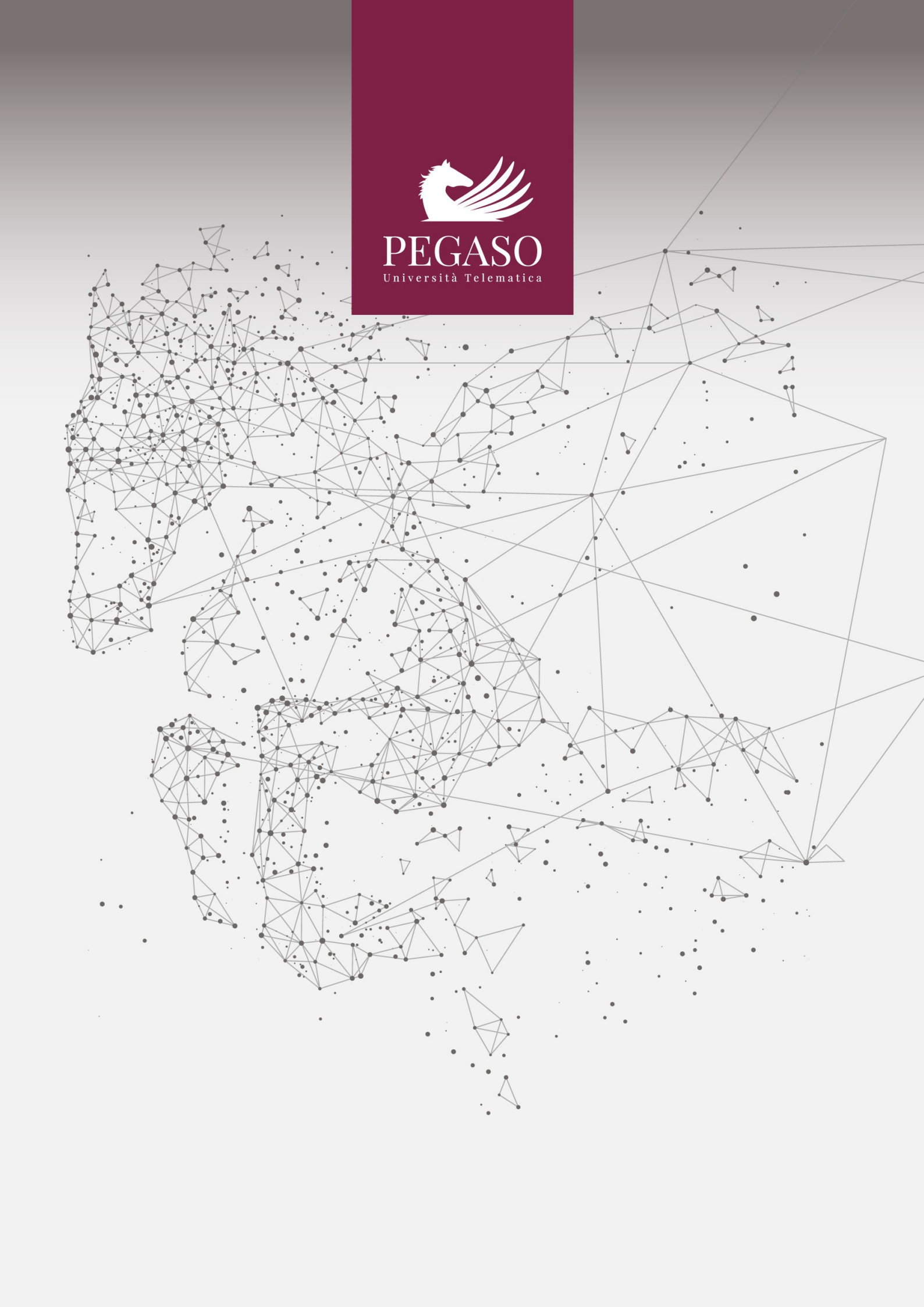

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1. Introduction to Narrative Forms

Narrative Forms are verb tenses that are used to talk about the past. They are often found in stories and descriptions of past events, such as personal anecdotes.

Narrative forms: past simple

We use the past simple

1. to talk about a finished event that happened at a specific time in the past.

I saw Paul last night.

I went to Brazil five years ago.

2. to describe a sequence of finished events in chronological order.

I took out my key, opened the door and walked in.

3. to talk about habits in the past.

Did your parents read to you when you were younger?

4. to talk about states in the past.

When I was a child, I didn't enjoy watching TV at all.

The house belonged to my father from 1990 to 2000.

5. in reported speech

She said she didn't want to join us

Narrative forms: past continuous

We use the past continuous

1. to describe an action in progress in the past, often to set the scene for a particular event.

I was sitting in the garden, reading a book.

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2. to talk about temporary situations in the past.

Rodolfo was living in South America at the time.

3. to talk about an event that was in progress in the past and was interrupted.

I was going out of the house when I heard a noise.

4. to talk about multiple actions in progress at the same time in the past.

While I was painting, you were watching TV.

5 to talk about anticipated events that did not happen.

We were going to Rome for a holiday, but then I broke my foot.

Narrative forms: past perfect

We use the past perfect

1. to refer to a time earlier than another past time, when this is needed to make the order of events clear.

The bird's wings had been clipped so it couldn't fly.

By the time the fire engine arrived, the house had completely burnt down.

Watch out! Be careful not to overuse the past perfect.

It is not necessary with before/after, which make the sequence of events clear.

Once we have established the time sequence, we can revert to the past simple.

2. in reported speech.

They said they had met before.[1]

[1] J. Bell and A. Thomas, *Gold First Coursebook New Edition*, Essex, Pearson Education Limited, 2014 (177)

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2. The Four Narrative Tenses

Note the use of the four narrative tenses in this story:

Meg and Liam McGowan got a nasty surprise when they were checking in at Heathrow airport yesterday with their baby, Shaun. They had won three free plane tickets to Rome in a competition, and they had been looking forward to their trip for months. But, unfortunately, they had forgotten to get a passport for their son, so Shaun couldn't fly. Luckily, they had arrived very early for their flight, so they still had time to do something about it. They ran to the police station in the airport to apply for an emergency passport. Meg went with Shaun to the photo booth, while Liam was filling in the forms. The passport was ready in an hour, so they hurried to the gate and got on the plane just in time.

The Four Narrative Tenses

1 We arrived at the airport and checked in.

We use the **past simple** to talk about consecutive actions or situations in the past, and for the main events in a story.

2. We were having dinner when the plane hit some turbulence.
At nine o clock most people on the plane were reading or were trying to sleep.

We use the **past continuous (was / were + verb + -ing)** to describe a longer continuous past action or situation which was in progress when another action happened, or to describe an action or situation that was not complete at a past time.

3. When we arrived at the airport, we suddenly realized that we'd left one of the suitcases in the taxi.

We use the **past perfect simple (had + past participle)** to talk about the 'earlier past', i.e. things which happened before the main event(s)

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4. We'd been flying for about two hours when suddenly the captain told us to fasten our seat belts because we were flying into some very bad weather.

We use the **past perfect continuous (had been + verb + -ing)** with action verbs (go, play, watch, etc.) to talk about longer continuous actions or situations that started before the main events happened and continued up to that point.

Non-action verbs (e.g. be, have, know, like, etc.) are not normally used in the past continuous or past perfect

Past perfect simple or continuous?

The past perfect continuous emphasizes the continuation of an activity. The past perfect simple emphasizes the completion of an activity.

Lina was crying because she'd been reading a very sad book.
Lina didn't want to see the film, because she'd already read the book.[2]

[2] C. Latham-Koening, C. Oxenden, K. Chomacki, *English File Upper-Intermediate Fourth Edition*, Oxford, Oxford University Press, 2020 (136)

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3. Useful Phrases for Narration

Some advice and phrases for telling a story

1. Use beginning phrases to start a story

Although we hear in some movies and books that telling stories are started with “once upon a time,” this is not commonly used in real life. Instead use beginning phrases to indicate to your listeners that a story is about to be opened.

Beginning phrases that you can use are:

It all started when

To begin

It all began when

2. Provide a background to set the scene of your story

Introduce to your listeners the setting of your story. By providing them a clear background, they will be able to imagine the scene of the story. This is your opportunity to use past continuous and past simple to distinguish between the background activities and the main story events.

Conjunctions or expressions that you can use are:

When

While

As

During

In the meantime

In the meanwhile

3. Use sequencing words

Continue giving details in the story in an organized way by including proper sequencing of events.

Sequencing words that you can use to continue or connect your story are:

First of all

Previously

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Initially

Once

Next

After that

Before that

Soon after

As soon as

After a while

Immediately/ right after

In an instant

Next

Finally

In the end

Just as/ after/ when/ then

At the same time

Later on

4. Use interruption words to create suspense

While you are telling your story, you may want to add some elements to make it even more interesting.

Interrupting phrases to add new elements in the story include:

Suddenly/ all of a sudden

Unexpectedly

Fortunately/ luckily

Miraculously

Sadly

Unfortunately

Coincidentally

Strangely

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5. Use linking words

Throughout your narration, you might need to give reasons for actions, mention contrasting information, or share about a result. Instead of presenting these details in a direct manner, weave them together by using linking words.

Good transitional words you can use are:

Because

As a result

Although

However

Subsequently

6. Use time words

Time words will enable your listener to know when the events took place. It will also allow them to better imagine the situation and determine how recent or old it was. Time words can be placed at the beginning or end of a sentence.

Examples of time words or expressions:

yesterday

today

this morning

last night

after _____ minutes

from ____ to ____

7. Describe emotions

Make your stories compelling by communicating the emotions that you experienced. Interesting stories don't just present details of when, where and what happened, but also include what triggered action and how you felt.

Example:

The news was so shocking.

I was speechless.

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Italy was devastating.

8. Use appropriate adjectives

Use different adjectives to draw a picture while telling your story. Adjectives help create better mental images and make your story more colorful and dramatic.

9. Use reporting verbs

Part of telling stories is quoting what other people said that may have resulted in triggering some events or actions in the story. To talk about the speech of other people, use the past tense of "say" which is "said".

Examples:

He said that…

I explained that…

We told them that…

10. Use correct tenses

When telling stories, you can use the four narrative tenses to tell events that happened in the past.

11. End your story well

When you are about to wrap up your narrative, prepare your listener to disengage from your story. End your narrative well by telling what finally happened in your story. Use a key phrase or word as well to hint that your story is about to end.

Some ending phrases and words you can use are:

Finally…

In the end…

Lastly…

At last

EXERCISES

Put the verb in brackets in the past perfect simple (had done) or continuous (had been doing). If you think both are possible, use the continuous form.

ex. His English was very good. He'd been learning it for five years. (learn)

1. I was really fed up because we …… for hours. (queue)

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2. She went to the police to report that someone ……her bag. (steal)

3. It …… all morning. The streets were wet and there were puddles everywhere. (rain)

4. She got to work late because she …… her phone at home and ……..go back and get it. (leave, have to)

5. I almost didn't recognize Tony at the party. He …….. a lot since I last saw him. (change)

6. The tourists' faces were very red. They …….. in the sun all morning and they …… any sun cream. (sit, not put on)

7. I could see from their expressions that my parents …….. (argue)

8. Jess had a bandage on her arm because she …… off her bike that morning. (fall)

9. I was amazed because I…… such an enormous plane before. (never see)

10. How long …….. before you realized that you were lost? (walk)

Read the short story and choose the correct forms of the verb

11. First Time Buyers

Last year, my wife and I bought / were buying our first house. We ***had already been living / were already living*** together for 5 years before we bought our house, so we ***knew / were knowing*** how to live together. I'll never forget the first house we ***looked / had looked*** at. It ***was / was being*** a small house in the suburbs with small windows. While we ***were walking / had walked*** around the house, I ***noticed / was noticing*** how dark and depressing it ***was / had been***. I ***was always living / had always lived*** in a house with a lot of light and big windows, so I instantly ***hated / was hating*** it. We ***saw / had seen*** a few more houses after that which were all quite nice. We ***ended / had ended*** up buying the second house that we ***visited / were visiting***. We ***had been seeing / had seen*** it twice before we ***bought / had bought*** it, just to be sure. I ***had been dreaming / was dreaming*** of this day for a long time. Now, we have moved in. I'm really happy.[3]

Translate these short accounts that demonstrate narrative tenses into Italian.

12. Britain declared war on Germany on 3 September 1939 after Germany had attacked Poland two days earlier. Britain had been trying to negotiate a peaceful settlement.

13. We were walking as usual one day, when all of a sudden, my dog ran off. She started to bark furiously. I saw a man sleeping face down on the sand. My dog continued to bark, but the man didn't wake up. He wasn't sleeping; he was dead. It was clear that the storm had washed up the body.

[3] C. Latham-Koening, C. Oxenden, K. Chomacki, *English File Upper-Intermediate Fourth Edition*, Oxford, Oxford University Press, 2020 (136)

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EXERCISE ANSWER KEY

1. I was really fed up because we had been queueing for hours.

2. She went to the police to report that someone had stolen her bag.

3. It had been raining all morning.

4. She got to work late because she had left her phone at home and had had to go back and get it.

5. I almost didn't recognize Tony at the party. He had changed a lot since I last saw him.

6. The tourists' faces were very tired. They had been sitting in the sun all morning and they hadn't put on any sunscreen.

7. I could see from their expressions that my parents had been arguing.

8. Jess had a bandage on her arm because she had fallen off her bike that morning.

9. I was amazed because I had never seen such an enormous plane before.

10. How long had you been walking before you realized that you were lost?

11. First Time Buyers

Last year, my wife and I bought our first house. We had already been living together for five years before we bought our house, so we knew how to live together. I'll never forget the first house we looked at. It was a small house in the suburbs with small windows. While we were walking around the house, I noticed how dark and depressing it was. I had always lived in a house with a lot of light and big windows, so I instantly hated it. We saw a few more houses after that which were all quite nice. We ended up buying the second house that we visited. We had seen it twice before we bought it, just to be sure. I had been dreaming of this day for a long time. Now, we have moved in. I'm really happy.

12. La Gran Bretagna dichiarò guerra alla Germania il 3 settembre 1939 dopo che questa aveva attaccato la Polonia due giorni prima. La Gran Bretagna aveva cercato di negoziare una soluzione pacifica.

13. Un giorno stavamo camminando come al solito quando, all'improvviso, il mio cane è scappato. Cominciò ad abbaiare furiosamente. Vidi un uomo che dormiva a faccia in giù sulla sabbia. Il mio cane continuò ad abbaiare, ma l'uomo non si svegliò. (Egli) Non stava dormendo, era morto. Era chiaro che la tempesta aveva portato a riva il corpo.

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